



Naval Singh stands centre stage as he receives the Coach of the Year award, flanked by N. Vaidyanathan, Assistant Vice President & Head – Sales and Distribution, The Hindu Group (left), and eight-time national table tennis champion Kamlesh Mehta. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Coach of the Year

Amol Muzumdar and Naval Singh were named Coach of the Year at the Sportstar Aces Awards 2026, held in Mumbai, recognising two very different but equally impactful coaching journeys in Indian sport.

India women's team bowling coach Aavishkar Salvi received the honour on behalf of Muzumdar, who could not attend the ceremony.

As head coach, Muzumdar guided the Indian women's cricket team to its maiden ODI World Cup triumph, a campaign defined by tactical clarity, calm execution under pressure and a deep belief in his players. After navigating early setbacks in the tournament, the team peaked at the

right moment, delivering a commanding performance in the final. Muzumdar's leadership also extended beyond strategy, with his inspirational messaging, including a widely discussed rallying speech before the final, strengthening the squad's confidence and unity.

"I would like to thank everyone for this award. It means a lot to me to be named Coach of the Year. I would also like to take this opportunity to thank the Indian women's cricket team, without whom I would not be here," Muzumdar said in a video message.

The former Mumbai batter was appointed head coach of the India women's team in October 2023 after a long and successful domestic career



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and an equally varied coaching journey.

Muzumdar retired after a 21-year first-class career in which he became one of the Ranji Trophy's most prolific run-scorers, amassing 11,167 runs in 171 matches, including 30 centuries. A stalwart of Mumbai cricket for 15 years, he later represented Assam and Andhra and won eight Ranji Trophy titles with Mumbai, though he never played for India.

Since retiring, he has coached age-group teams at the BCCI's National Cricket Academy, led Mumbai in domestic cricket, worked with Rajasthan Royals in the IPL and also served as part of South Africa's coaching staff during its 2019 tour of India. The Dronacharya awardee Naval Singh, meanwhile, has played a key role in shaping the rise of javelin thrower Sachin Yadav. Under Naval's guidance, Sachin won gold at both the National Games and the Federation Cup in 2025 and claimed silver at the Asian Championships in his first international competition.

He also finished fourth at the World Athletics Championships in Tokyo with a personal best of 86.27m, the best performance by an Indian athlete at the event.